oakleaf PARTNERSHIP

PREPARED FOR ST. JAMES'S PLACE | NOVEMBER 2026

Data and strategic insight: examples from our work

Where data and strategic insight have helped clients anticipate workforce trends, hire more effectively and rely less on reactive recruitment.

Our market intelligence comes from **HRAG**, our own platform, designed and built in house, which reads HR job adverts across the UK every day and records who is hiring, for which roles, at what level and at what published salary, combined with our own placement data from over 21 years of HR, Reward and Payroll recruitment and with published labour market sources. The examples below show how that insight changes what a client does before recruitment begins.

TALENT MAPPING, RUN FOR ST. JAMES'S PLACE, NOVEMBER 2026

A live map of the financial services HR market, before a single role is briefed

Ahead of this response we ran for St. James's Place the exercise we would run before any programme of recruitment, using our data for the 60 days to 8 November 2026.

Competitor organisations. In the 60 days to 8 November, wealth and investment employers advertising HR roles included Standard Life, with three Head of People Technology roles between £80,000 and £140,000; NatWest Group, with reward and benefits roles; AJ Bell, with a Head of Reward; and Vanguard, True Potential, Quilter and 7IM. Reward and talent acquisition are where the sector is hiring: reward makes up about three times the share of financial services HR adverts that it does across all sectors, and talent acquisition about twice.

Salary levels. Fewer than one in twenty financial services HR adverts publish a salary, so we calibrate against our own placements. The middle half of our permanent financial services placements since January 2024 sat between £61,000 and £100,000, with a median of £80,000. Like for like salary ranges on the UK roles we have recruited for have moved little on a year earlier, with HR systems and HR technology the exception.

Candidate availability. Overall candidate supply has risen for three and a half years, yet by September HR Business Partners and Payroll Specialists were in short supply. Financial services HR advertising in our feed dipped through October and by 8 November was back above its late August level, at 134 live adverts against 114. The insight for St. James's Place is to set remuneration parameters role by role now, start business partner and payroll searches early, and draw on the deep pool for generalist roles before competitors' hiring builds further.

SOURCING STRATEGY, SOVEREIGN WEALTH FUND

A global search across the major financial centres

A Middle East sovereign wealth fund needed a confidential replacement for its highly regarded Head of Total Reward and Performance, in post for five years. We ran a global search across the major financial centres, including London, Singapore and New York, drawing on our network and our research capability, and assessed each candidate on technical knowledge, motivation and appetite to relocate. The search reached beyond the obvious centres: we sourced a candidate based in Australia who had previously been Regional Head of Reward in investment banking in Singapore.

SOURCING STRATEGY, ABU DHABI HEADQUARTERED BANK

Looking beyond banking for transformation experience

The bank was transforming its People function and needed SVP level HR Business Partners with C suite partnering and change experience. Rather than search banking alone, we targeted candidates from banking and from retail and consumer organisations, researching talent at retail banks in Europe and Singapore that had been through a similar transformation, alongside international banks and retail organisations already in the region. The two appointments came from a retail organisation in Dubai and a retail bank in Italy, one of them from outside banking altogether.

ANTICIPATING TRENDS, BETWEEN ASSIGNMENTS

The HR Market Pulse

Each month we produce the HR Market Pulse from HRAG's daily data and published labour market sources, so that we and our clients can plan ahead of the market rather than react to it. The October edition finds that employers' net hiring outlook for October to December is +23%, that HR Business Partners have moved into short supply while Payroll Specialists remain scarce, and that HR systems and HR technology is the one area where like for like salaries have risen. The aim is fewer offers declined on salary and fewer searches restarted because the brief was set against the wrong market.

> Financial services is our largest single sector, around one in five of our placements since January 2024, with reward, business partnering, payroll and talent acquisition the largest specialisms. Client references from HR leaders in financial services and investment firms are available on request.

Sources: HRAG, our daily feed of HR adverts from employers' career sites, job boards and LinkedIn, 10 September to 8 November 2026, a sample rather than the market's true size; our placement records; KPMG and REC Report on Jobs, September 2026; Indeed Hiring Lab, October 2026; ManpowerGroup Employment Outlook Survey, September 2026.